

LawStack

(working title)

A Practice Management Platform for Indian Advocates & Law Firms

Note: This document is a product concept, not legal advice. Anything about Indian law here (DPDP Act, Bar Council of India Rules, court precedent) should be reviewed by a qualified lawyer before it is relied on for compliance or marketing claims.

1. The Idea in One Paragraph

Right now, most Indian advocates and small law firms run their practice on WhatsApp groups, paper diaries, and Excel sheets. LawStack replaces all of that with one simple, secure workspace where a lawyer or firm can manage cases, hearings, documents, clients, billing, and their team — in one place, built specifically around how Indian legal practice actually works.

The one thing this platform is built around, more than any single feature, is trust: making sure no one — not even the platform's own owner — can casually look into a firm's case files. That's the core promise the whole product is designed to keep.

2. Who This Is For

Priority	User type	Why they matter
1st	Independent advocates	Solo lawyers — the biggest group of users. They need something simple, not complicated.
1st	Small & mid-size law firms	Multiple lawyers and associates working together — they need team and role management.
2nd (later)	Judges	A separate, lower-priority product track. This would be sold to government, not to the open market, and is built much later.

3. How Access & Security Work (the Core of the Product)

This is the foundation everything else is built on, so it's explained in detail here. The short version: nobody can just sign up. Access always flows downward from someone already trusted, and no one — including the platform owner — can see across different firms' data.

At a glance, the whole platform flows in one direction: Public Website → Login → Platform Control Plane (you, the platform owner) → you provision a tenant → that tenant gets its own login and its own isolated Tenant Workspace. No step in that chain can be skipped or reversed.

3.1 Who can create accounts

There is no public "Sign Up" button anywhere on the platform. The only public screen is Login. Every new account must be created by someone with authority above it:

- You (the platform owner) create accounts only for firm/advocate owners — never for their staff.
- A firm/advocate owner invites and creates accounts only for their own team (associates, clerks, juniors).
- Nobody can create accounts for a layer they don't manage. This isn't just a rule — it's built into the system so it can't be bypassed.

3.2 The Platform Control Plane

The Platform Control Plane is your own workspace as platform owner — the only thing you can log into. It's organized into five areas:

Area	What it's for
Dashboard	A high-level view of the whole platform: how many tenants are active, usage trends, and any alerts that need your attention.
Tenant Administration	Search and view the tenant list, suspend or upgrade a tenant, and see a read-only tenant profile (plan, usage, status) — never a tenant's actual case or client data.
Tenant Provisioning	Where new tenants are created (see the flow below).
Audit Center	Platform-level audit logs — every tenant created, every suspension, every emergency "break-glass" access event (see Section 3.4).
Platform Settings	Platform-wide configuration — notification providers, billing plans, and which features are switched on for which tenants.

Tenant provisioning flow, step by step

1. From Tenant Provisioning, you choose the tenant type: Individual Advocate (a single-person account) or Law Firm (a multi-user account with the role hierarchy from Section 3.6).
2. You complete a Registration Wizard that captures verified details for that tenant — a KYC-style check, plus type-specific details (bar enrolment number for an individual advocate; firm registration details for a law firm) — before any access is granted.
3. The system creates the tenant record, a bare-bones owner account shell (name + verified email only, no password set by you), and a unique, encrypted "vault" just for that tenant's data.
4. The Tenant Workspace is created, and the owner sets their own password and switches on two-factor authentication (MFA) using an authenticator app — not SMS, since SIM-swap fraud is a real risk in India. This step cannot be skipped.
5. The owner invites their own team from inside their own workspace — not through you. Law firm owners typically invite associates and clerks right away; an individual advocate can invite an assistant or clerk later, or simply work solo. Either way, this keeps you structurally out of the loop of who has access to a tenant's data.

Note: For demo/wireframe purposes, three example tenants are used consistently across this document and the HTML wireframes: Oakwood (law firm), ABC Legal (law firm), and Rahul Advocate (individual advocate) — each with its own login and its own isolated workspace.

3.3 The login screen

- Just one form: work email + password + two-factor code. No sign-up link.
- A clear message on screen: "This platform is invite-only. Your firm administrator sends access — there is no public sign-up."
- "Forgot password" only resets the password — it can never be used to skip two-factor authentication.
- Two-factor authentication is required every single time someone logs in, not just the first time.

3.4 How data is encrypted — "even the platform owner can't see a firm's files"

There are three honest ways to build this, with different trade-offs. Recommended: Option 2.

Option	How it works	Trade-off
1 — Standard	The platform holds the master keys, and access is controlled by internal rules/policy.	Trust depends on the company following its own policy — not on the math being impossible to break.
2 — Per-firm encryption (recommended)	Every firm gets its own unique encryption key. No one has standing access. Any emergency access requires two people to approve it, and is permanently logged.	Technically possible to override in a genuine emergency, but every single instance is logged and needs deliberate, multi-person action — nobody can quietly peek.
3 — Fully locked (zero-knowledge)	Data is encrypted on the user's own device before it ever reaches the servers. The platform never holds the key at all.	The platform then can't offer search, AI drafting help, or auto-matching with court records — most of the smart features become impossible to build. Also, if a firm loses their key, their data can never be recovered.

Option 2 is the right balance: it delivers almost all of the trust benefit — "even our own engineers can't casually look into your case files, and any access is logged and requires your sign-off" — without giving up the smart features (search, reminders, auto-fetching court data) that make the product actually useful. Option 3 (fully locked) is right for something like a password manager, but not for an active workspace tool like this.

How this is enforced (not just promised)

- Each firm's encryption key is created the moment their workspace is set up, and it is always stored in a locked, wrapped form — never as plain, readable text.
- Unlocking a firm's key requires someone to be logged in as that specific firm — checked at the database level, not just the app level.
- The platform owner's own login has no technical ability to bypass this — it's built into the system's architecture, not just a company rule.
- Any genuinely necessary access (a critical bug, a legal order) goes through a special "break-glass" process that is permanently logged and, wherever legally required, the firm is notified.

3.5 Access control inside a single firm

There's a second, separate problem: even within one firm, not everyone should see every case. Some matters need extra confidentiality — a conflict of interest, a sensitive family case, a partner-only matter.

Recommendation: solve this with simple permission rules, not a second layer of encryption for every case. Encrypting every case separately sounds more secure, but in practice makes the key management far too complex, slows the system down, and makes basic things like firm-wide billing reports or searches very difficult to build.

What works instead — permission-based visibility

- Every case has an assigned team (partner, associates, clerk), set by the firm owner or a partner with that permission.
- By default, a person only sees the cases they're assigned to — though the firm owner can choose to let, say, partners see everything, while clerks see only their assigned cases.
- A case can be marked "restricted" — visible only to specifically named people, and hidden from everyone else in the firm, including other partners if needed.
- This is enforced the same way firm-to-firm isolation is enforced — at the database query level — so it can't be accidentally bypassed by a coding mistake.

Note: Conflict walls are a real, everyday need for Indian firms — for example, a litigation team on one side of a case while a corporate team at the same firm advises a related company, or a family/matrimonial matter needing extra discretion. Larger firms will expect this feature before they trust the platform with sensitive work, so it should be planned for from day one — even if it ships slightly after the first version.

3.6 Who can do what — role summary

Role	What they can do
Platform owner	Create/suspend firm accounts, see basic usage info (plan, storage used) — cannot view any firm's actual case or client data.
Firm owner	Full control of their firm: invite/remove staff, assign roles, set case visibility rules, manage billing.
Partner / senior advocate	Access set by the firm owner — usually broad visibility across the firm's cases.
Associate / junior lawyer	By default, only sees the cases they're assigned to.
Clerk / admin staff	Narrowest access — usually just calendar, documents, and task lists, with no billing/financial data unless specifically given.

4. What the Product Actually Does (Feature List)

4.1 Case & Matter Management

- Track case number (CNR), court, case type, parties involved, relevant laws/sections, filing date, and current stage.
- A clear status pipeline: Filed → Admitted → Hearing → Reserved → Judgment → Disposed → Appeal.
- Link related cases together, keep case notes and a timeline, and track order sheets.
- Store the next hearing date and its purpose, plus opposing counsel's details.

- Attach documents, tasks, and billing directly to each case.
- Assign a team to each case (this drives who can see it — see Section 3.5).
- Flag a case as restricted/confidential.
- Search, filter, bulk-import, and archive cases.

4.2 Calendar & Hearing Reminders

- A master calendar with a cause-list view, and automatic detection of clashing hearings.
- Reminders sent over WhatsApp, SMS, email, and in-app notifications.
- Automatic client notification when a hearing is adjourned.
- Tracking of recurring compliance deadlines and the court holiday calendar.
- Syncs with Google Calendar and Outlook.

4.3 Document Management

- Upload documents per case, with automatic categorization and version history.
- Scanned documents and PDFs become searchable through OCR (text recognition).
- Ready-made templates for common documents (vakalatnama, standard petitions, affidavits).
- Share documents through secure, expiring links instead of email attachments.
- Export all of a case's documents as a single bundled PDF.

4.4 Client Relationship & Communication

- Client profiles linked to their cases, with a communication history log.
- A client-facing status portal (planned for a later phase).
- Automatic WhatsApp updates on case status.
- A digital client intake form.
- A check for conflicts of interest against existing case parties.

4.5 Billing & Payments

- Flexible fee structures: fixed fee, hourly, per-hearing, or retainer.
- GST-compliant invoicing, with UPI/Razorpay payment collection.
- Expense tracking per case, and automatic reminders for outstanding dues.
- Firm-wide revenue dashboards.

4.6 Team & Task Management

- Role-based access, as described in Section 3.6.
- Case assignment, a workload view for the team, and internal task lists.
- Approval workflows — for example, a junior drafts a document and a partner approves it.

4.7 Automatic Court Data Sync

- Automatically fetch case status from eCourts, NJDG, and High Court websites (rolled out court by court).

- Automatically update hearing dates and flag any discrepancies.
- Look up a case directly using its CNR number.

4.8 Analytics & Insights

- Case load and disposal trends, and revenue analytics.
- Team productivity, and a view of which upcoming deadlines are at risk.

4.9 Judges Module (later phase, separate product track)

- Docket management, case assignment view, and an order-drafting workspace.
- This would need direct engagement with the judiciary/e-Committee rather than a normal sales process, so it's a separate track from the core product.

4.10 Platform Owner's Control Panel

This is the Platform Control Plane described in Section 3.2, made up of five areas:

- Dashboard — platform-wide health: active tenants, usage trends, alerts.
- Tenant Administration — search tenants, suspend/upgrade accounts, view read-only tenant profiles (plan, usage, status) — never case content.
- Tenant Provisioning — create a new tenant, choosing Individual Advocate or Law Firm, via the Registration Wizard (see 3.2).
- Audit Center — platform-level audit logs: tenant creation, suspensions, and emergency "break-glass" access events.
- Platform Settings — platform-wide configuration, including support tickets and which features are switched on per tenant.

4.11 What Makes This Different From a Generic Practice-Management Tool

These three features are what separate LawStack from a generic practice-management tool — each solves a problem specific to the Indian legal system in 2026. Each also carries a real risk if built carelessly, so the risk is treated as part of the feature, not an afterthought.

Old-Law-to-New-Law Lookup Tool (IPC/CrPC/IEA → BNS/BNSS/BSA)

The problem: Trial courts are currently running cases under both the old criminal codes (for offences committed before 1 July 2024) and the new codes (BNS, BNSS, BSA) side by side. Mistakes in mapping old sections to new ones are causing real delays in legal filings.

The feature: while an advocate is typing a legacy section number into a draft, the tool instantly shows the matching modern section, flags relevant precedents, and can format a footnote matching the citation style used by the relevant High Court.

Risks to plan for

- Old and new sections don't always match up one-to-one — some were split, merged, or redefined. The tool must clearly flag this ambiguity ("this section was split into three new provisions — please confirm which applies") rather than silently guessing.

- Precedents and footnotes should always be suggestions the advocate reviews and approves — never inserted automatically. Auto-inserting citations would recreate the very error this feature is meant to prevent.
- Footnote formatting differs by court, so build for a small number of High Courts first rather than trying to cover all of them at once.

Rollout plan

- Phase 1: Basic old-to-new section lookup as a drafting suggestion, based on official government concordance tables.
- Phase 2: Add precedent suggestions, with clear warnings wherever a mapping isn't one-to-one.
- Phase 3: Automatic footnote formatting for 2–3 major High Courts, expanding from there.

Invite-Only Client Access (Following BCI Rule 36)

The problem: Rule 36 of the BCI Rules bans advocates from advertising or soliciting clients, directly or indirectly. As shown in the P.N. Vignesh case (see Section 6.2), this is actively enforced against platforms too, not just individual lawyers.

The feature: there is no public lawyer directory, no ratings, and no way for a stranger to find or get matched with a lawyer through the platform. A client only ever enters the system because a lawyer who already represents them sends an invite — the same invite-only design already used for team access in Section 3, applied to clients as well.

Risks to plan for

- Avoid describing this using the term "zero-knowledge" — that has a specific technical meaning (Option 3 in Section 3.4) that this platform doesn't use. "Closed-network" or "private client channel" are accurate terms instead.
- This is as much a legal and marketing decision as a technical one — the terms of service, marketing copy, and in-app wording all need to consistently say "invite-only, no discovery," since courts (as the Vignesh case shows) look at what a platform actually does, not just what it's labelled.

Rollout plan

- Phase 1: Ship as a natural side-effect of the invite-only design already in Section 3 — no separate feature needed.
- Phase 2: Get this positioning formally reviewed by a lawyer before any client-facing portal goes live.

Automatic Filing Defect Checker

The problem: court registries manually check thousands of filings a day for basic formatting mistakes — missing signatures, wrong indexing, incorrect margins, wrong page order — creating major bottlenecks. Each court has its own filing rules, and these usually aren't available in a computer-readable format.

The feature: a scanning tool that checks an uploaded draft against a specific court's filing requirements before it's submitted, and flags problems in advance.

Risks to plan for

- This effectively needs one custom rule-set per court, not one generic tool — each court's filing manual likely has to be manually encoded by hand.
- Treat this as a multi-year effort. Don't promise coverage of many courts early — an unreliable checker is worse than none, because advocates will stop trusting it after the first mistake it misses.

Rollout plan

- Phase 3: Pilot with 1–2 courts that already have relatively mature e-filing systems and well-documented rules.
- Phase 4: Expand court by court, based on how the pilot goes and demand from users.

5. How the System Is Built (In Plain Terms)

The technical model: one shared system serving every firm, but each firm's data is walled off both technically and cryptographically from every other firm.

- Database: every table is tagged by firm, with database-level rules that physically prevent one firm's data from leaking to another — even if there's a bug in the app's code.
- Encryption: each firm gets its own encryption key (Option 2 from Section 3.4) — the platform owner has no standing access.
- Case-level access: a second layer of rules on top of firm isolation, checking "does this specific person have access to this specific case" (see 3.5).
- File storage: cloud storage, kept separate per firm and encrypted with that firm's own key.
- Login: mandatory two-factor authentication and role-based access, aware of which firm each person belongs to.
- Background tasks: automatically checking court websites, sending WhatsApp/SMS/email, generating invoices.
- Audit trail: every sensitive action is logged with who did it and when; emergency access is logged in a way that can never be edited or deleted.
- Hosting: servers based in Mumbai (AWS/GCP), so Indian data stays in India.

Scaling as firms grow

- Solo advocates and small firms: share the same underlying system, kept apart by the rules above (cost-efficient).
- Large firms (50+ users): get their own separate database for extra isolation and performance, offered as a premium option.

6. Following Indian Law

6.1 The Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023

This is India's main data privacy law. On this platform, the company itself is a "Data Fiduciary," and also effectively processes data on behalf of each firm, who are themselves fiduciaries for their own clients' data.

Where things currently stand: the DPDP Rules were notified on 13 November 2025, starting an 18-month phased rollout. The Data Protection Board is already functioning (Phase 1). The Consent Manager framework takes effect on 13 November 2026 (Phase 2). Full enforcement of every obligation begins 13 May 2027, with no grace period after that (Phase 3). Penalties can go up to ₹250 crore per violation.

What this means the platform needs to do:

- Get clear, specific consent when a client's details are first entered — no pre-ticked boxes, and consent must be easy to withdraw.
- Use client data only for the case/billing purpose it was collected for.
- Collect only the data that's actually needed — nothing extra.
- Have a clear process for reporting any data breach to the Data Protection Board and to affected people within the required time.
- Allow data to be deleted once a case is closed, except where the law requires records to be kept (court records often must be retained).
- Have proper data-handling contracts in place between the platform and every firm using it.
- Meet security requirements — which the encryption and access-control design in Section 3 already satisfies.
- Handle minors' data with extra care where relevant (family/custody cases are common) — needs verifiable parental consent and no behavioural tracking of children.
- Keep processing logs for at least one year.

6.2 The Advocates Act & Bar Council of India (BCI) Rules

Rules against advertising and soliciting clients apply to advocates themselves, not to the platform as a software provider — but marketing language still needs care. Messaging should avoid implying that the platform helps advocates "get more clients" in a way that could be read as soliciting on their behalf.

Note: Enforcement here is active and recent. In *P.N. Vignesh v. Chairman and Members of the Bar Council (Madras High Court, 2024:MHC:2515, decided 3 July 2024)*, the court found that directory-style platforms (Quikr, Sulekha, JustDial) enabled prohibited touting under Rule 36, ruled they could not claim IT Act safe-harbour protection, and directed the Bar Council to pursue action against both the advocates and the platforms involved.

Because of this, the product deliberately has no public lawyer listings, ratings, or client-discovery feature of any kind — a client can only join the system because their own advocate invites them in. See Section 4.11 for how this is built in as an architectural choice, not just a policy.

6.3 Attorney-Client Privilege

The access and encryption design in Section 3 — firm isolation, and no standing access even for the platform owner — is itself the mechanism that protects privilege on a shared platform like this. This should be a headline point in how the product is marketed, not a buried technical detail.

7. Suggested Build Order

Phase 1 — MVP: Security foundation + core workflow

- Full access chain: platform owner → firm owner → team invites (Section 3.2).
- Per-firm encryption and firm-level data isolation (Section 3.4).
- Basic roles: owner / partner / associate / clerk, built so restricted cases can be added later without a rebuild (Section 3.5).
- Case management, calendar with WhatsApp/SMS reminders, document upload, basic client contacts, task lists.

- Basic old-to-new law lookup tool (Section 4.11, Phase 1).
- Invite-only client access, as a natural result of the access design (Section 4.11, Phase 1).

Phase 2 — Firm-grade features

- Restricted/confidential case flag (builds on the Phase 1 foundation).
- GST-compliant billing and invoicing, client portal, analytics dashboard, document templates.
- DPDP consent-capture workflows, ready well ahead of full enforcement in May 2027.
- Precedent suggestions and ambiguity warnings for the law-lookup tool (Section 4.11, Phase 2).
- Legal review of the invite-only client access positioning before it fully launches (Section 4.11, Phase 2).

Phase 3 — Automation & scale

- Automatic case-status sync with eCourts/NJDG, and conflict-of-interest checks.
- Payment gateway integration, and a formal two-person-approval emergency access process.
- A dedicated, separate database option for large firms.
- Judges module (separate track).
- Automatic footnote formatting for 2–3 major High Courts (Section 4.11, Phase 3).
- Filing defect checker pilot with the first 2 courts (Section 4.11, Phase 3).

Phase 4 — Ecosystem

- Mobile app for clients, and support for regional languages.
- AI-assisted drafting using case context (carefully scoped against the encryption limits from Section 3.4).
- Filing defect checker expanded court by court (Section 4.11, Phase 4).

8. Key Product Decisions

These were open questions in the earlier draft. Here's the working decision on each, so the team can build against something concrete. Each is still a judgment call, not a legal ruling — revisit any of them as the product gets real user feedback or formal legal review.

Q: What is the exact emergency ("break-glass") access process — who approves it, how many approvers, what triggers it, how is the firm notified?

Decision: Two named approvers are required every time: the platform's technical lead (e.g. CTO) and a separate compliance/security owner — never one person acting alone. It can only be triggered by one of three things: a critical security bug that risks data integrity, a valid legal or court order, or a firm's own request (for example, an owner who is locked out and consents to assisted recovery). The affected firm is notified automatically by email and an in-app banner — immediately, unless a legal order specifically prohibits notification — and the full event is written to a permanent, uneditable audit log the firm can view.

Q: Should two-factor authentication (MFA) be mandatory for every user, or configurable by the firm owner?

Decision: App-based (TOTP) MFA is mandatory for every role that can see billing or case data — owner, partner, associate. For clerk/admin-only staff with narrow access, the firm owner can enable an SMS-based fallback to

reduce onboarding friction, but the firm owner can also switch on a "strict mode" that forces app-based MFA for everyone in the firm, no exceptions.

Q: Which courts and states should be targeted first for automatic court-data syncing (eCourts/NJDG)?

Decision: Start close to home: Madhya Pradesh (Jabalpur High Court and MP district courts), matching the platform's initial focus on solo advocates and small firms in Tier-2/3 cities. In parallel, add Delhi High Court and Bombay High Court, since they have the most mature e-filing systems and will validate the integration on well-documented systems. Expand state by state after that, based on demand and how each court's data is exposed.

Q: How should a "restricted" case be handled in firm-wide billing reports — should it count toward revenue totals?

Decision: Yes — restricted cases still count toward the firm's total revenue figures, so the dashboards stay accurate. But they appear only as an aggregated line (for example, "Restricted matters — 3 cases, ₹X total") with no case name, client name, or detail visible to anyone outside the assigned team. Only the assigned team and the firm owner can drill into the specifics.

Q: What is the account recovery process when a firm owner is locked out — without creating a backdoor that undermines the encryption promise?

Decision: Recovery requires a formal re-verification of identity (similar to the original KYC-style onboarding check), followed by a mandatory 72-hour cooling-off period before access is restored. If the firm has other partners, they are notified before recovery completes. This recovery event is treated exactly like emergency access in Section 8 above — same dual-approval, same permanent audit log — so it can never be used quietly or by one person alone.

Q: Who maintains and updates the old-law-to-new-law (concordance) table as courts issue clarifications?

Decision: An in-house legal research function — starting with a single dedicated legal researcher or consultant — owns the table. It is built from official government concordance tables and cross-checked against them, and reviewed at least once a quarter, with updates pushed out sooner whenever a relevant High Court issues a clarification.

Q: Who signs off on the invite-only client access positioning before the client-facing portal ships?

Decision: An external lawyer with specific experience in BCI compliance and technology platforms will review the terms of service, marketing copy, and in-app wording. This legal review is now a required gate before the Phase 2 client portal can go live — not an optional step.

Q: Which 1–2 courts should the filing-defect-checker pilot start with, and how will filing rules be sourced and kept current?

Decision: Delhi High Court and Bombay High Court, since both have relatively mature e-filing systems and publicly available filing manuals to build the initial rule-set from. Filing rules are sourced directly from each court's official filing manual and practice directions, manually encoded by the team, and reviewed against new circulars or amendments on a regular schedule rather than a one-time build.

Note: This is a working product concept and will keep evolving as it's validated with real advocates and firms. Treat every phase, feature, and decision here as a starting point for discussion, not a final decision.